

TOYS CATCHING UP WITH ROBOTS

The border between the world of toys and robots is no longer a differentiating line, but an overlapping band—with many of today's toys being nothing short of robots albeit lower-end ones! With sensors, actuators, microprocessors and wireless units, the making of today's high-tech toys is a scientific task

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Remember the toys we played with when we were young? Small steam-propelled boats, colourful wind-powered toys like windmills and kites, mechanical toys like giant-wheels, trains and drum-beating rabbits, little plastic and metal cars and vans that were friction-powered—we just had to pull them back and let them rush forth. These were the fanciful toys of our childhood, which we used to buy from neighbourhood stores, street ped-

dlers and temple-side vendors. Those were lot of fun, but apparently are not so exciting for today's children. Times are changing, and today's toy shops look more like science labs. Even the simplest toy is a bump-and-go robot, which was so difficult and costly to mass-manufacture a decade ago.

Inter-disciplinary research, reducing manufacturing cost, easier avail-

ability of components, increasing scientific temper amongst children, and the rising affluence of the educated class are fuelling the demand and supply of educational and entertaining toys, which are so high-tech that they can easily qualify as robots or mini-computers.

"Nowadays, it is very difficult to draw a line between a toy and a robot.

As the toys are getting advanced, a simple inexpensive robot finds it difficult to compete with the features and functions of a sophisticated toy, at least from the user's

